

their ECE Hall of Fame in 2018.

Attributing his success to his late father, Shiv Shankar Nayak, a very bright and accomplished man for his generation, Sanjay acknowledges that he supported him in all his decisions. "In the 80s, if someone in your family worked a government job, the family could push you in the same direction. However, I wanted to go to the US, and my father supported me in that decision. He was my first role model," he shares.

Excellence is not innate, but absorbed and learnt, till it becomes a habit. For Sanjay, absorbing this habit came from watching his father's attention to detail. "My dad was passionate about everything he did. His handwriting was almost like calligraphy. He wrote beautifully, even for mundane tasks, like making a shopping list, demonstrating a culture of excellence. Whether it was practising yoga or his profession, he excelled at everything," he recalls fondly.

Sanjay grew to pass on this heirloom to his children. "They always strive to do their best and set high standards for themselves," he states proudly.

The three Vs—Verilog, VHDL, VLSI

Life after college for many involves precise decision-making, lots of ifs and buts, hits and misses. For Sanjay, life put him in the right place, at the right time, and he used that to his advantage to do the right things, never missing to excel in an opportunity that knocked his door.

After completing his post-graduation in 1987, he joined a startup, Gateway Design Automation (GDA), in Boston with less than 20 people. "People talk about startups in 2024, I started my career from a startup in 1987!" he exclaims.

This team at GDA was the same team that had invented the first language in the world that would allow hardware to be described in software—Verilog. GDA opened its Verilog language to IEEE, making it industry's first hardware description language standard. For two years, Sanjay worked on developing the Verilog simulator with the team. Around the same time the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) in the US had started developing VHDL as a language and Sanjay worked on developing one of the world's first VHDL simulators.

"The first seven years in my career, from 1987 to 1995, involved working on cutting-edge technologies in electronics design and automation (EDA), which was a sunrise industry then. Gateway Design Automation was acquired by Cadence in 1989 for \$80 million, which was a very big deal at that time," he recounts.

He went on to move to India and helped in the

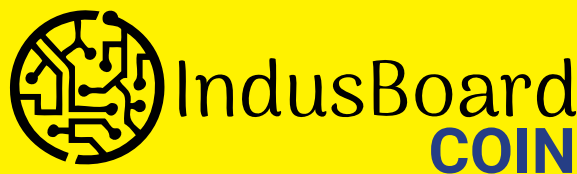


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